

If Search feels broken or painfully slow, Microsoft also documents troubleshooting steps (including running the Search and Indexing troubleshooter).

8) Taskbar: Make it a dashboard

Your taskbar is not a status bar. It's your always-visible launcher. Microsoft's taskbar settings let you control badges, flashing, multi-monitor behaviour, and auto-hide – useful on small laptop screens and in clutter-heavy workflows.

Step-by-step: Open Taskbar settings quickly

1. Right-click an empty area on the taskbar.
2. Select Taskbar settings.

From here, look at two sections:

- Taskbar items (what icons show up)
- Taskbar behaviors (how it acts)

Step-by-step: Turn off taskbar clutter (Widgets/Chat/etc.)

1. Taskbar settings → Taskbar items.
2. Toggle off what you don't use (common candidates: Widgets, Chat/Teams, extra search entry points).
3. Keep Task View ON if you plan to use virtual desktops later in this book.

Guiding rule: if you don't click it weekly, it doesn't deserve permanent space.

Step-by-step: Set taskbar behavior for laptop screens

In Taskbar behaviors, adjust what suits your day:

- Automatically hide the taskbar for maximum vertical space.
- Decide if you want badges and flashing (useful for messages/alerts; annoying for everything else).
- If you use two monitors, enable the taskbar on all displays.

9) Fix the system tray

The right side of the taskbar (system tray/notification area) is where important utilities hide: Wi-Fi, battery, sound, Bluetooth,



TROUBLESHOOTING

Sometimes Start refuses to pin/unpin apps, or taskbar pinning malfunctions after an update. Before you go hunting for hacks, do the boring repair steps.

Step-by-step: Basic repair for Start/taskbar oddities

1. Restart Windows (a real restart, not sleep/wake).
2. If pinning still fails:
 - Open Command Prompt as administrator
 - Run: `sfc /scannow`
 - Restart again

If Search itself is acting up, Microsoft documents a dedicated set of fixes for Windows Search issues (including the troubleshooter route).

VPN, antivirus, cloud sync. Windows 11 often tucks icons behind an overflow arrow.

Step-by-step: Show system tray icons you need

1. Right-click taskbar → Taskbar settings.
2. Find system tray options / "Other system tray icons".
3. Turn on the icons you want always visible:
 - Bluetooth (if you use earbuds)
 - VPN (if you use office VPN)
 - OneDrive/Drive sync (if you rely on it)
 - Security app indicator (if relevant)

Do this once and stop playing hide-and-seek.

10) Pin smart, not hard

Start is your launcher. Taskbar is your "always-on belt". Pin only what you need constantly – otherwise the taskbar becomes a crowded shelf.

Step-by-step: Pin an app to taskbar

1. Open the app.
2. Right-click its icon on the taskbar.
3. Choose Pin to taskbar.

Recommended taskbar pins for most people:

- Browser
- File Explorer
- One core work app (Excel/Word/IDE)
- One comms app (Teams/WhatsApp)
- Optional: cloud sync or notes app

Everything else can live in Start. **d**